Chapter 1

GLORIOUS BHARAT



"India has withstood the shocks of centuries, of hundreds of foreign invasions. It is the same land that stands firmer than any rock in the world, with its undying vigour, indestructible life. It's life is immortal and we are the children of such a country".

- Swami Vivekananda

LEARNING OUTCOMES

- Identify major empires of Bharat and their rulers between 700 CE and 1000 CE
- Assess the economic and cultural prosperity of Bharat
- Discuss the major contributors of each dynasty during this period
- Assess the nature of the state and highlight cultural and social changes

INTRODUCTION

700 CE to 1000 CE witnessed dramatic developments in the social and political spheres that significantly changed Bharat. This was a period of great strength and achievement for Bharat.

Kanyakubja or Kannauj in the heartland of Bharat was a flourishing metropolis* of that time. A bustling economic and cultural centre, it caught the attention of many rulers from various parts of Bharat. Between 1 CE and 1000 CE, Bharat was a leading economic superpower with almost 32% of the world's GDP*.

Three major empires experienced their rise and fall during this time period. They were the Rashtrakutas (from the south), Palas (from the east) and the Pratiharas (from the west and north).

Bharat saw a vast cultural and religious resurgence during this time. Puranas became very popular. Dharmashastras were held as the source of fundamental law. Literature and architecture attained great heights. Dharma was protected by rulers and unquestioningly adhered to by common citizens. Bharatiyas crossed frontiers and traversed the seas to far-off lands including Java, Sumatra, Malay, Kambuja and Champa.

POLITICAL LANDSCAPE OF BHARAT BETWEEN 700 CE AND 1000 CE

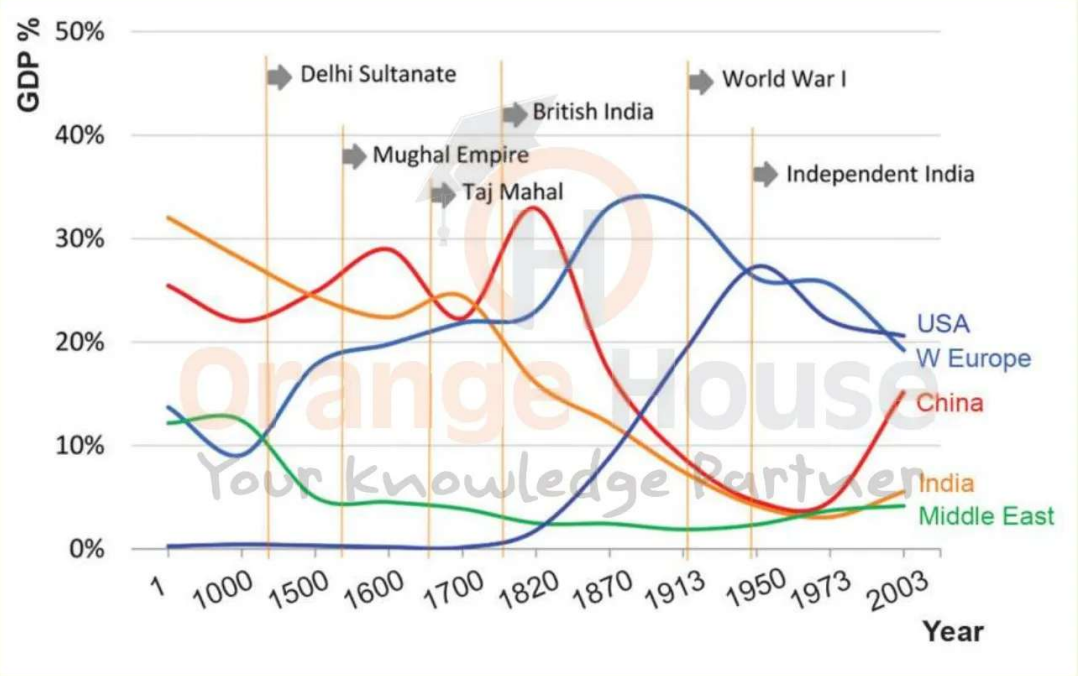
The geographical landscape of Bharat extended from the Himalayas in the north to the Indian Ocean in the south and Hindukush Sulaiman Range in the northwest to Arunachal which was part of greater Assam of that time in the east. The Sulaiman and Kirthar Ranges stood strong and daunting* in the northwest. These

Metropolis : Chief city of a kingdom or country
GDP : Gross Domestic Product – Measure of health of a country's economy.
Daunting : Difficult to deal with

seemingly impassable ranges had a few narrow passes that connected Bharat to Central Asia and West Asia. The long coastline of southern Bharat enabled the Cholas to establish a strong naval force and thereby develop trade relations with other southeastern countries.

The unparalleled textile products of Bengal were in great demand across Arabia, Persia and China. Metal implements, particularly iron, were used for manufacturing agricultural tools. The large number of bronze idols, especially from southern Bharat, bear testimony to the proficiency* of artisans in metal craftsmanship. According to Chinese traveller and historian Hiuen Tsang's testimony brass, silver and gold were produced in plenty. Improved agricultural techniques and expansion of settlements resulted in cultivation of cash crops*. This led to development of several agro-based industries. There was also a rapid increase in sugar production.

All these developments culminated into Bharat becoming the wealthiest nation in the world. Bharat's GDP was more than a quarter of that of the entire world. Owing to her unthinkable wealth reserves, Bharat was famed as the golden bird (Sone ki Chidiya). In fact, most of the Arabic and Turkic invaders who ravaged Bharat after 1000 CE for establishing Islamic rule also ended up plundering enormous wealth. Diamonds were primarily found only in ancient Bharat until they were later discovered during the 18th century in Brazil. This caught the attention of merchants and governments from all over the world.



Before we endeavour to study all of Bharat, let us look closely at one region in Bharat - Kanyakubja or Kannauj. From the 8th to 12th century CE, Kannauj (in present day Uttar Pradesh, 80 kms from Kanpur) was one of the most significant, sought after and fought over regions. The Rashtrakutas, Palas and Pratiharas had a keen interest to take control of Kannauj at that time. Control of the central and northern portions of Bharat usually rested with those empires that ruled Kannauj. The control for Kannauj by the three kingdoms was referred to as the **Tripartite Struggle**.

CLASSROOM DISCUSSION

We can see in the above graph that Bharat contributed to 32% of the total wealth created in the world in 1 CE but it reduced dramatically from 1820 CE. What do you think could have been the reasons?

Proficiency : Skilled in doing something **Cash crops :** Plants grown to source raw material, not food

IMPORTANCE OF KANNAUJ

- Kannauj was located in the fertile plains of the Ganga-Yamuna doab*. Owing to the fertility of the land and abundant natural resources, agriculture flourished and Kannauj developed as a center for trade and commerce.
- Geographically Kannauj was situated at an elevated height and easy to fortify and to protect it from invasions.
- Kannauj was an important center for trade because of its connectivity to the ancient silk route.
- The wealth of Kannauj attracted the best of learned people of those times. The presence of numerous universities and literary works in the area stand testimony* to this fact.
- Control of Kannauj implied control of the large expanse of the Gangetic plains and was a symbolic power center.



Doab : Is a tract of land located at the meeting point of two large rivers
Testimony : Proof of something

THE THREE MAJOR POWER CENTERS OF BHARAT

THE RASHTRAKUTAS

By the middle of the 8th century, the Rashtrakutas of Manyakheta rose to power. Previously, the Rashtrakutas were chieftains under the Badami Chaulukyas. However, the Rashtrakuta ruler Dantidurga through his successful military expeditions started becoming independent of the Badami Chaulukyas. He won over the last Badami Chaulukya ruler Kirtivarman II and established the Rashtrakuta empire in 753 CE.

KRISHNA I – THE VISIONARY WHO BUILT THE KAILASA TEMPLE

As Dantidurga did not have any children to succeed him, his uncle Krishna I took over in 758 CE. The Chaulukyans regrouped, attacked and Krishna I convincingly defeated them.

Krishna I was a great visionary and built the spectacular rock-cut temple of Kailasa in Ellora.

ROCK-CUT TEMPLE OF KAILASA, ELLORA, AURANGABAD





Krishna I commissioned the unique Kailasa temple in Ellora. Legend goes that his queen had taken up a *vrata* to not have a morsel of food until she saw the shikhara (tower above the sanctum sanctorum) of the majestic temple that the royal couple were building. Architects from all over the country were invited to give their ideas. An architect from Paithan gave a unique solution - to carve out a temple top-down from the massive rocky mountains. This way, the shikara would be revealed first and the queen could end her *vrata*. Hence, the Kailasa temple is the biggest monolithic structure (made of single rock) in the world that was constructed by vertical excavation - that is, removing debris from the top towards the bottom of the temple..

CLASSROOM DISCUSSION

Do you think it would have been an easy task to carve a temple out of the mountain from the top? What could have been the challenges faced by the architects? How do you think they solved it? How long do you think it would have taken for them to build the temple?

DHRUVA & THE TRIPARTITE STRUGGLE

Dhruva, a son of Krishna I, was a dynamic ruler who defeated his brother to rule over the Rashtrakuta kingdom. He set his eyes on Kannauj and had to face-off with Dharmapala (Pala) from the east and Vatsaraja (Pratihara) from the west. He handed a crushing defeat to both their armies and planted the Rashtrakuta flag in Kannauj.



GOVINDA III - THE PEAK OF RASHTRAKUTA POWER

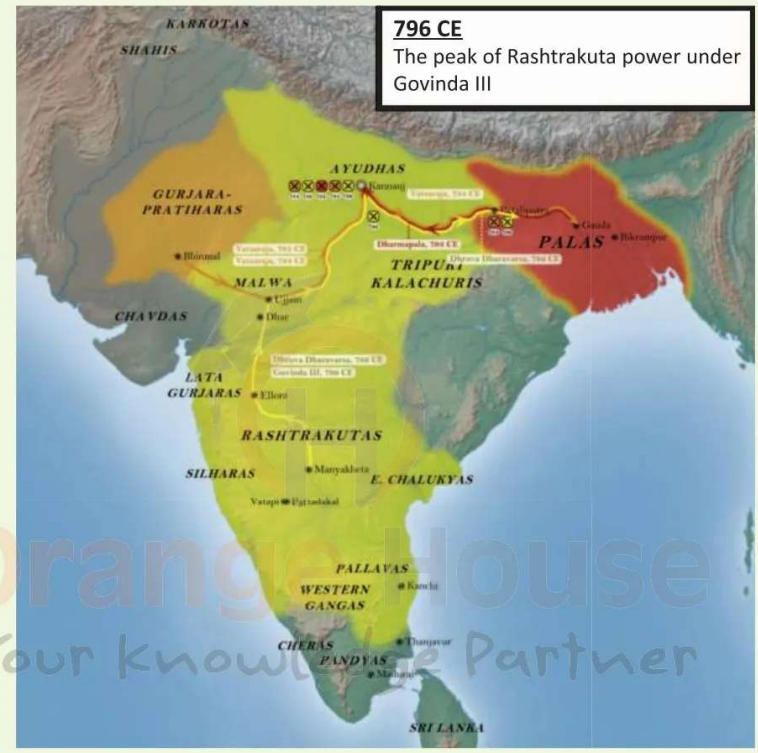
After the death of Dhruva, the young Govinda III stepped up in 793 CE. He had to face the wrath of his brothers who didn't get the throne. Kambha was the eldest and most powerful. Govinda III proved his

worthiness as king by defeating a confederation of 12 rulers single-handedly. He didn't go on a revenge spree* though. Convinced of their loyalty, he appointed his brothers as viceroys – **Kambha** for Gangavaadi, **Indra** for Laata.



After settling disputes at home, Govinda III captured Kannauj.

Taking advantage of Govinda's focus in the north, the Pallava, Pandya, Chera and Ganga rulers joined hands to attack his southern territories. Govinda raced down south and by 802 CE defeated all of them. Most rulers from Kashmir to Kanchi submitted to him. Even the embassy of Ceylon (Sri Lanka) surrendered to him. Govinda III was the crown jewel of the Rashtrakutas.



AMOGHAVARSHA - THE LONGEST PEACEFUL REIGN

Govinda III was succeeded by his young son **Amoghavarsha** in 814 CE. The Eastern Chaulukyas and Gangas created widespread chaos and rebellion in the empire after the death of Govinda III. King Amoghavarsha's reign continued for the longest period of 64 years, despite constant troubles thrusted by the enemies. Every time there was a conflict, he had to defend and reclaim his territories and return peace to the state.

Amoghavarsha was known for his religious pursuits. He spent a lot of time with Jaina monks. He lived his life as a synthesis of the choiciest principles of Jainism and Hinduism. He was an author himself and a patron of authors. He wrote the Kavirajamarga, the earliest work on Kannada poetry. The fine workmanship in his palace reflects his aesthetic sense. He is celebrated as the builder of the city of Manyakheta (Malkhed).

DECLINE OF THE RASHTRAKUTAS

After Amoghavarsha's death in 878 CE, a series of wars ensued. **Krishna II**, the new king, strengthened his military support through matrimonial alliances.

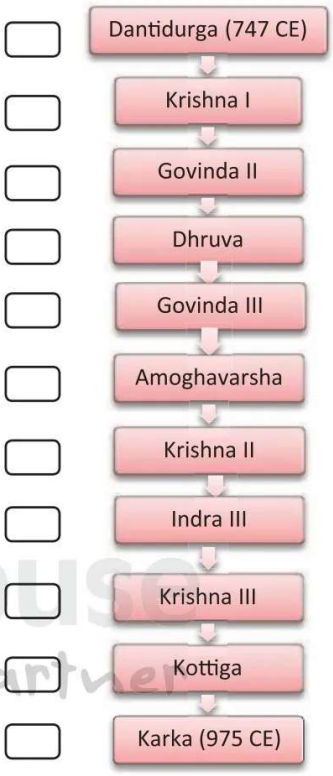
Spree : Outburst of extreme activity

Indra III defeated Mahipala and planted the flag of Rashtrakutas again in Kannauj. **Krishna III** again expanded the kingdom over the entire Deccan region. He established Rashtrakutas as the lords of the Deccan again, penetrating until Rameshwaram in 965 CE.

The later rulers **Khottiga** and **Karka** lacked military capacity and hence the Rashtrakutas were defeated and plundered. Tailapa II, a descendant of the Badami Chaulukyas and a feudatory of the Rashtrakutas, grabbed the opportunity to openly revolt against the Rashtrakutas. By 975 CE, he established his rule and became the overlord of the Deccan. Thus began the rule of **Western Chaulukyas,** with Kalyani as their capital (also called Kalyani Chaulukyas).

CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Can you find the number of years these kings ruled?



GLORIOUS RULE OF THE RASHTRAKUTAS

Despite repeated wars, the Rashtrakuta empire was effectively administered. Let us look at some of the important facets of their administration:

- The kingdom was divided into rashtras (provinces) governed by Rashtrapatis. These were further divided into Vaishyas, under Vaishyapatis. Next sub-division was the Bhukti comprising 50-70 villages, under supervision of Bhupatis. Each village was under a Gramapati. It is interesting that many of these terms are used even today. The central authority was the king and his immediate circle of ministers.
- The kings took up to Vaishnavism or Shaivism, but they supported Buddhists and Jains equally. There was religious harmony.
- Education was given prime importance – Bijapur had its own university at Salatogi.
- Kannada literature blossomed under the Rashtrakutas. Famous Kannada poets Pampa and Ponna lived during this period.
- Copper mines in the region became a major contributor to the state's revenue. The capital Manyakheta and Devagiri were diamond trading centres. The port of Bharoch (Gujarat) was ever-buzzling with export activities. Trade between Deccan Bharat and Arabs flourished. Horse trading was an important and profitable business.

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THE GURJARA-PRATIHARAS

The Gurjara-Pratihara dynasty (800 CE - 1100 CE) was brought back into prominence by Nagabhata I who was instrumental in preventing Arab armies from moving towards the east of the Indus River. According to Arab accounts, they were successful in stopping Muslim conquests of Bharat for nearly 400 years. Nagabhata I brought many regions that were being overrun by the Arabs under his kingdom. Nandipuri, Malwa, part of Rajputana and Gujarat came under his rule that is estimated to have been till 756 CE. Kannauj was their capital. Amongst the famous rulers of this dynasty, the name of Raja Mihira Bhoja (Bhoja I) especially stands out for his successful efforts in driving out invaders, as well as his contribution in the fields of science and art. Under Bhoja I, the territory of the Gurjara-Pratiharas spread from the foothills of the Himalayas in

the north to the Narmada river in central Bharat and from the lower Ganga valley in the East to Sindh in the west.

The next prominent ruler of the Pratiharas was **Vatsaraja** who ascended the throne in 778 CE. Vatsaraja enlarged the kingdom and defeated Dharmapala (Pala king of Bengal). While Vatsaraja was fighting with Dharmapala and also expanding his kingdom, the Rashtrakuta king Dhruva saw an opportunity and attacked Vatsaraja. Dhruva won and captured Kannauj.

FURTHER EXPANSION OF THE GURJARA-PRATIHARAS

Vatsaraja was succeeded by his son **Nagabhata II**. Nagabhata II was known to be an effective warrior from a very young age and captured forts like Anartta and Malava. He expanded the kingdom towards northern Gujarat and was successful in winning over Saindhava territory in western Kathiawar. Andhra, Kalinga and Vidarbha paid tribute to Nagabhata II. He is credited with winning back Kannauj after a fierce battle with the Pala ruler Dharmapala.

Nagabhata II was trying to consolidate his power but was defeated by the Rashtrakuta king Govinda III around 810 CE. However, Nagabhata II was able to establish the Gurjara-Pratiharas firmly in northern Bharat even after this defeat. The greater part of Rajputana, Kathiawar peninsula and lands stretching in the east to include Gwalior, Kannauj and Kalanjara. From a small, local power centre, the Gurjara-Pratiharas had grown into a major military and political power.

MIHIRA BHOJA AND OTHER PRATIHARA RULERS

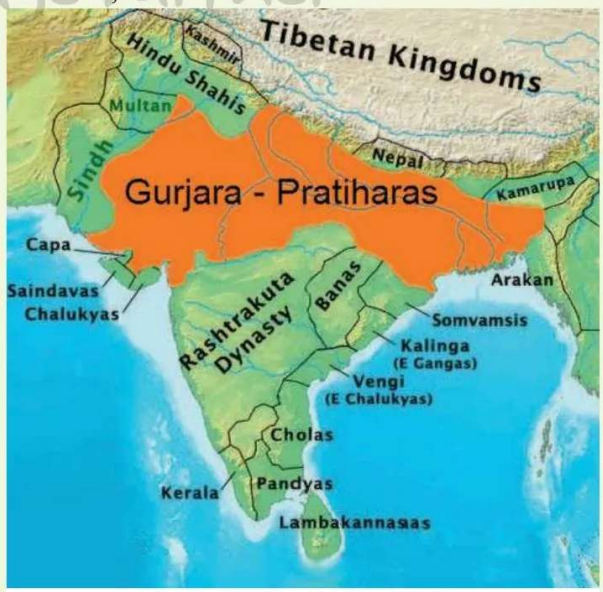
Nagabhata II's grandson, son of Ramabhadra, **Mihira Bhoja** (Bhoja I) ascended the throne in 836 CE and operated with Kannauj as his capital. Mihira Bhoja was one of the greatest rulers of the Gurjara-Pratiharas but this didn't come easy.


Raja Mihira Bhoja (836 - 885 CE)

By 843 CE, Bhoja brought some of the key regions his father had lost back into their kingdom. But soon he faced off in a battle with the Pala king Devapala where Mihira Bhoja lost. To change his fortunes, Bhoja moved south to invade Rashtrakuta territories. Here he faced defeat at the hands of Dhruva (around 860 CE). The Kalachuri king Kokalla also served a loss to Mihira Bhoja.

However, Mihira Bhoja didn't lose hope and waited for an opportune moment. With the passing away of Devapala, the Palas faced constant raids by the Rashtrakutas. Using this opportunity, Mihira Bhoja attacked Bengal and defeated Pala king Narayanapala and conquered his territories. Bhoja then trained his sights on the Rashtrakuta regions in Gujarat and was able to win over large tracts of land. Mihira Bhoja's reign lasted 46 years and his kingdom included Kathiawara peninsula, Punjab in the northwest, Kalachuri territories of Gorakhpur, Awadh and Bundelkhand. Under Bhoja I, the territory of the Gurjara-Pratiharas spread from the foothills of the Himalayas in the north to the river Narmada in central Bharat and from the lower Ganga valley in the east to Sindh in the west.

Raja Bhoja stood as a fort of defence against Islamic aggression and was a great empire builder.



Gurjara Pratihara Empire - 900 CE

Arab historian Sulaiman on Raja Mihira Bhoja

> …the Gurjara king maintains numerous forces and no other Indian prince has so fine a cavalry… Among the princes of India, there is no greater foe of the Muhammadan faith than he.

When Mihira Bhoja passed away in 885 CE, he was succeeded by his son **Mahendrapala I**. Mahendrapala I maintained the kingdom left by his father and further extended the kingdom. His spiritual preceptor Rajasekhara composed many literary works like Karpuramanjari, Prapanch Pandav, Bhrinjika and many more that throw light on the grandeur of the Pratihara kingdom and Kannauj.

CLASSROOM DISCUSSION

What can we learn from Raja Mihira Bhoja's life and his character?

GURJARA-PRATIHARA ADMINISTRATION

Effective administration helped the Pratiharas constantly expand their empire and defend against external aggression. The rulers adopted the highest position and titles like Maharajadhiraja and Parambhaterak. Samantas were the feudatory chiefs who were appointed by the rulers.The Samantas provided military and administrative support to the king and helped in local governance. Various positions were created for effective governance that included:

Tantrapala	-	King's representative in Samanta states
Dandanayaka	-	Head of Justice and Administration
Baladhikrat	-	Army chief
Dandapashika	-	Police chief
Kottapala	-	Head of fort
Mahattar	-	Village administration head

States were divided into bhuktis, bhuktis into mandalas, mandalas into cities and villages. Councils administered the cities and were called Goshti, Sanviyaka and Panchakula.

LIFE IN THE TIMES OF THE PRATIHARAS

There are many sources including literature, excavations, inscriptions, monuments, temples and foreign traveller accounts that shed light on society, art, culture and more during the times of the Gurjara-Pratiharas. Rajashekara's dramas narrate the prosperity of the kingdom and the high status accorded to women of those times. The Dharma of building water tanks, temples and other works of charity were done during the Gurjara -Pratihara period. Temples commissioned by Mihira Bhoja stand tall till today. The Gurjara-Pratiharas were patrons of arts, architecture and literature. The prosperous and open socio-religious life of the people of the Gurjara-Pratihara kingdom was a high point in the history of Bharat. The Chaturbhuj temple in Gwalior has inscriptions dating back to 876 CE. The Pratihara rulers supported all religious sentiments. This is supported by the fact that many generations of the Pratihara rulers starting from Devaraja were devotees of Vishnu, Shiva, Bhagavati and Surya.

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Khajuraho Temple in Madhya Pradesh



Bateshwar Temple complex, Morena

The Gurjaras are known for their sculptures, carved panels and open pavilion style temples. Their style of temple building is seen at Khajuraho, now a UNESCO* World Heritage site.

CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Attempt to draw the lineage of Gurjara Pratihara kings in a flow chart.

DECLINE OF THE GURJARA-PRATIHARAS

Mahendrapala I's reign ended in 908 CE and was succeeded by Mahipala. The period between 913 CE and 944 CE was filled with multiple losses for the Pratiharas under Mahipala and the subsequent rulers. Mahipala was defeated by his eternal foe, the Rashtrakuta king Indra III. Kannauj was plundered. There were many rulers after Mahipala that included Rajyapala (960 CE–1018 CE) and the last ruler Yashpala after whom the Gurjara-Pratiharas power came to an end.

THE PALAS

RISE OF THE EARLY PALAS

By the middle of the 8th century, the Pala dynasty started a new epoch in Bengal and Bihar. Realising the need for a strong central empire the independent petty chiefs came together and recognised the suzerainty of one political ruler whom they all trusted - **Gopala**. He was elected as king by the general body of people. Gopala established peace in the consolidated lands of eastern Bharat by defending against invasions. The dynasty ruled for 18 generations over four centuries.

DHARMAPALA CAPTURES KANNAUJ

In 770 CE **Dharmapala** succeeded his father, Gopala. The long-drawn power struggle with Gurjara-Pratihara from the west and Rashtrakutas from the Deccan, for ruling over Kannauj started during Dharmapala's time. Dharmapala was defeated by **Vatsaraja** (Pratihara dynasty), who in turn was defeated by Dhruva (Rashtrakuta dynasty). **Dhruva** turned back south after his victory. Dharmapala took this opportunity to conquer Kannauj and the major northern territories. In the presence of the chiefs of the surrounding kingdoms, Dharmapala placed his representative Chakrayudha as the king of Kannauj. By 800 CE, his victorious military campaigns expanded the empire from Indus in the west, to Kedara (Himalayas) in the north and beyond river Narmada in the south.

DEVAPALA'S GOLDEN REIGN

Devapala was born to Dharmapala and a Rashtrakuta queen Rannadevi. He was as skilled and brave as his father. When he was crowned the king in 810 CE, he peacefully inherited the vast empire and firmly

UNESCO : United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization

established his authority. Devapala appointed his cousin Jayapala as his military general and undertook daring military missions. In the north-east, the king of Pragjyotisha surrendered without a fight and at Utkala (Odisha), the ruler abdicated his capital and fled away. He exterminated the last traces of Hunas (nomadic tribe from Central Asia) and proceeded to Kamboja. He also kept a check on his constant rivals, Bhoja I (Gurjara-Pratiharas) and Amoghavarsha (Rashtrakutas). He subjugated the Pandyas in the south. According to a later inscription by Narayanapala, Devapala's campaigns expanded the kingdom from the Himalayas to the Vindhyas and from the eastern to the western seas. Devapala ruled for at least 35 years.

The Pala empire's extent and glory diminished after Devapala. There was political turmoil in the kingdom following his death. Devapala's nephew Vigrahapala (son of Jayapala) took over the throne.



Pala empire under Devapala (810 - 850 CE)

DID YOU KNOW?

Devapala's fame rose beyond the borders of Bharat. When the king of the Sailendra dynasty (that ruled Java, Sumantra, Malay) requested him for a grant of 5 villages to support a monastery he had built inside Nalanda University, Devapala accepted. He held a privileged position in the Buddhist world.

MAHIPALA RESTORES THE PALA GLORY

Over the next five generations, the Palas lacked the vigour of their forefathers and lost a significant chunk of their territory. Powerful invaders like the Chandellas and Kalachuris stormed the kingdoms towards the end of the 10th century CE. Around the same time, the Kambhoja Gaudapatis declared their independence and conquered parts of western and northern Bengal. When the Pala kingdom shrunk to just parts of Bihar, there rose a dynamic Pala ruler who brought back the lost vitality – **Mahipala I**.

When Mahipala I took over in 988 CE, he recaptured Northern and Eastern Bengal within just 3 years of his accession. He restored the Buddhist monasteries that were built by his forefathers. His name is glorified in the ballads and folklore of Bengal.



Lineage of the Palas

DECLINE OF THE PALAS

The rise of feudal power led to the disintegration of the Pala Empire. Vijaya Sena, conquered Bengal, fighting the kings of Gauda, Kamarupa and Kalinga. He established independent power in Bengal immediately after the demise of Ramapala. The Pala dynasty found its end after nearly 400 years of rule.

Let us explore some of the facets of Pala's glorious rule – effective administration, flourishing art architecture and more.

ADMINISTRATION BY THE PALAS

The early Palas could effectively maintain a vast kingdom because of their sound administrative policies. They adopted the Gupta's style of management and made it more efficient. Monarchical rule was followed. He was advised by the Prime Minister. The kingdom was divided into Vuktis (provinces), Vishayas (divisions), Mandalas (districts). The Palas patronised both Buddhists and Hindus. They gave land grants to

priests, temples, monasteries and peasants. Even the feudatory chiefs who served the empire by providing military services were given land grants. The Palas appointed an elaborate list of government officials– vassal kings, foreign minister, head ambassador, tax collector, accountant, head of land measurements, chief justice, police forces, secret service, head of dairy farms, goat farms, buffalo farms, to just name a few. Many copper plate inscriptions found from this era stands testimony of their superior administration. There was peace and harmony in the society because of the extensive public welfare activities undertaken like digging wells, establishing townships and serving justice.

PALA'S EXCELLENCE IN ART & ARCHITECTURE

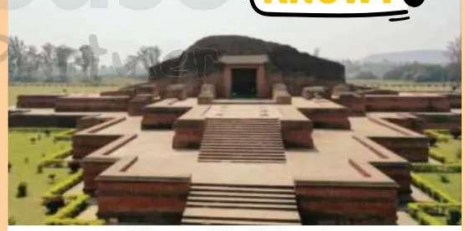


Somapura Mahavihara, Paharpur

Somapura Mahavihara, Paharpur built by Dharmapala is the largest Buddhist vihara in the Indian subcontinent. It was an educational center with residential facilities consisting of 177 rooms. It was built around a spacious courtyard with a Stupa in the center. The site covers an area of 27 acres of land that includes a quadrangular court measuring more than 900 feet. Dharmapala's father Gopala I had established the Odantapuri Vihara, the second oldest Mahavihara after Nalanda University.

DID YOU KNOW?

Dharmapala established the famous Vikramashila University, with 114 teachers and about 1000 students. It produced eminent scholars like Atisha Dipankara (founder of the Sarma traditions of Tibetan Buddhism). Subjects like philosophy, grammar, metaphysics, logic etc. were taught here. It specialised in Tantrism and Vajrayana sect of Buddhism, housing several temples within the complex. There were six huge colleges with a big building at the centre.



Vikramashila University

Taking inspiration from this architecture, Buddhist monasteries in Myanmar and Indonesia were designed. Sculptural art and terracotta art reached their pinnacle during Pala rule. The Pala bronzes are considered to be examples of matured art. In the Buddhist manuscripts found from the region, more than 400 paintings are featured – this shows the artistic genius of the times. These paintings have influenced the Tibetian and Nepali paintings of the later 14th century.

FLOURISHING LITERATURE OF THE PALAS

The Pala's patronised several Sanskrit scholars. Many Buddhist Tantric works were authored and translated during the Pala rule. Sandhyakara Nandi was a talented Sanskrit poet who was patronised by the last Pala king Madanapala. He composed the most acclaimed literature of the times, Ramcharita, that described the conquest of Varendra (north Bengal) by King Ramapala. He interestingly compares the life of Ramapala and the Ramayana and earned the title Kalikalavalmiki for his work.

TRADE AND COMMERCE IN THE PALA LANDS

The main source of revenue for the state was from agriculture. Rice, sugarcane, mango, bamboo, coconut were the important agricultural products. The empire thrived in agro-based products. The Pala kings granted land to the farmers. Mineral resources were abundant in the region. Iron ore existed in plenty. They knew the process of smelting ore and were famous for manufacturing the double-edged sword. Bengal became the sought-after harbour for fine quality cotton fabrics and maintained trade of cotton goods with distant countries, like Arabia and China. Silk industry was very popular in Bengal and had a worldwide market. Gur (jaggery) produced in Bengal, was exported to countries like Ceylon, Arabia and Persia.

SOCIAL, CULTURAL AND RELIGIOUS RESURGENCE

Having looked at the major kingdoms that existed in this epoch* let us take a glimpse at the social, cultural, religious and literary aspects that were prevalent.

- This period (700 CE to 1000 CE) witnessed the continuation of the Dharmic lifestyle of the people from the previous era. There was also, the assimilation of new ideas from different thought systems. Dharmashastras became the basis for the conduct of all the people across the social strata.
- During this period women continued to be the center of the family system. They took part in all the social and religious activities. They held the rights to inherit property, manage real estate and express their opinion on politics and governance. Women were at par with men in education.
- Temples formed the nerve center of the economy - Textiles, metal making, toolmaking and jewellery design industries rose to great heights. Merchants enjoyed prosperity and supported the society by contributing to temple building, education, creating lakes, etc.
- Emperors maintained huge armies. Hence lots of soldiers were paid well. Kings became patrons of Vedas and Vedic sacrifices and donated graciously to the priests. Thus all sections of society lived prosperously with interdependence and mutual respect.
- This age saw a huge cultural and religious resurgence*. Among the trading class, Jainism gained popularity. Great scholars like Adi Shankaracharya, Ramanuja, the Alvars and the Nayanars lived and spread the Bhakti tradition that superseded all inequalities in the society. The idea of individual Bhakti became popular. Emphasis was laid on love, self-surrender, truth, morality and cleanliness. Women seers* like Andal, Akka Mahadevi, and Karaikkal Ammaiyar inspired people into the spiritual tradition of Bhakti.

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CLASSROOM DISCUSSION

Why do you think the temple formed a central node in the social ecosystem of this period? Was there more to a temple, than just being a place of worship?

CONCLUSION

The period between 700 CE and 1000 CE witnessed a glorious display of valour, prosperity, and cultural resurgence. Great leaders ruled their empires in a dharmic way to find their place in the endless list of glorious rulers of Bharat. This was a period of great strength and achievement for Bharat. The rise and fall of the three major empires – Rashtrakutas, Gurjara Pratiharas, Palas – were witnessed in this epoch. The country saw vast cultural and religious resurgence and the Puranas served as a great source in bringing together the various sects of people. Art and architecture witnessed tremendous developments and concept of religious places (tirthas) strengthened the unity of Bharat. The rulers of Bharat served as protectors of Dharma. Philosophical literatures were generated in abundance during this period. Initial raids of external aggressors were thwarted but that was to change in the coming years.

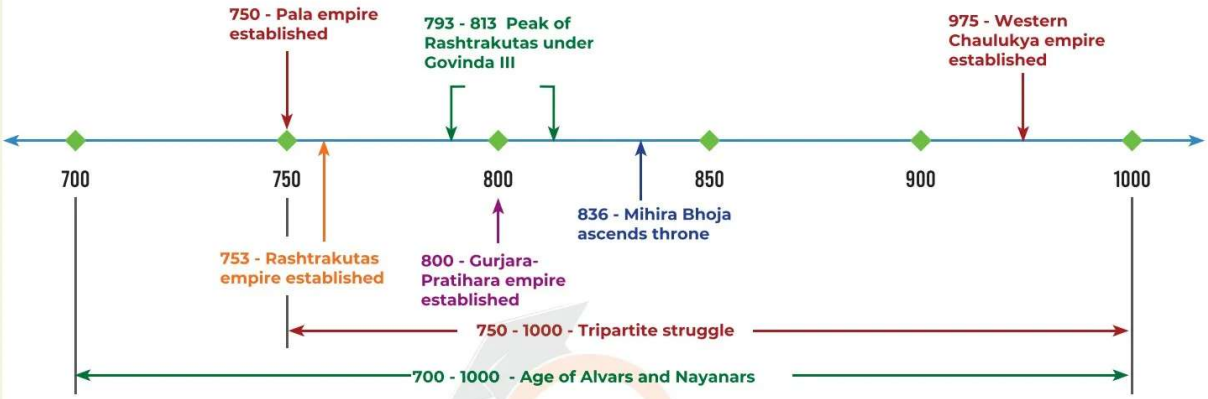
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Epoch : Period of time **Resurgence :** Rising again to prominence **Seers :** One who sees with spiritual eyes

KEYWORDS

- Kannauj
- GDP
- Sone ki Chidiya
- Rashtrakutas
- Palas
- Gurjara-Pratihara
- Tripartite Struggle
- Krishna - I
- Ellora
- Amoghavarsha
- Mihira Bhoja
- Nagabhata
- Dharmapala
- Vikramashila
- Adi Shankaracharya
- Ramanuja

RECAP WITH TIMESCALE



QUESTIONS

MULTIPLE CHOICE QUESTIONS

1. The Rashtrakutas were the chieftains of _____ dynasty.
   a) Eastern Chaulukyas b) Kalyani Chaulukyas c) Badami Chaulukyas d) Pallavas
2. Under the reign of _____ , the Rashtrakuta empire extended to its maximum extent.
   a) Govinda I b) Govinda III c) Dhruva d) Amoghavarsha
3. _____ was the Gurjara-Pratihara king who stopped Arab armies from moving towards the east of the Indus River.
   a) Dharmapala I b) Bhoja I c) Nagabhata I d) Nagabhata II
4. True or False
   Statement A : King Dhruva of the Rashtrakutas won over King Vatsaraja of the Pratiharas.
   Statement B : King Dhruva of the Rashtrakutas won over King Dharmapala of the Palas.
   a) A alone is true b) B alone is true c) Both are false d) A & B are true

MATCH THE FOLLOWING

Raja Mihira Bhoja	He held a privileged position in the Buddhist world
Vatsaraja	Under him, Gurjara-Pratihara empire expanded from foothills of the Himalayas in the north to the Narmada river in the south
Devapala	He captured forts like Anartta and Malava
Nagabhata II	His dramas depicted the social life during the rule of the Gurjara-Pratiharas
Rajashekara	He defeated Dharmapala and expanded the kingdom, but got defeated by Dhruva in turn

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ANSWER BRIEFLY

1. Who built the Kailasanatha temple at Ellora? What are its special features?
2. Who was the Rashtrakuta king who ruled the longest? Why was his reign considered peaceful?
3. Who established the Western Chaulukyas? How did they end the rule of the Rashtrakutas?
4. Why were the cities of Manyakheta and Devagiri important to the Rashtrakutas? What were the main sources of revenue for the Rashtrakutas?
5. How was the military expansion of Nagabhata II important to the Gurjara-Pratiharas?
6. Give 2 examples to explain the social life under the Pratiharas.
7. Give 2 reasons on why Devapala's rule was called the golden period of Pala's reign?

ANSWER IN DETAIL

1. What is GDP? Between 1 and 1000 CE, how did Bharat contribute to 32% of world GDP?
2. What is Tripartite Struggle? Why was Kannauj an important city to rule?
3. Write a short note on the achievements of any 3 kings of the Rashtrakuta clan.
4. Explain 4 major examples highlighting the glorious rule of the Rashtrakutas.
5. Why was Raja Mihira Bhoja's rule important in the reign of the Gurjara Pratiharas?
6. Mahipala's name is glorified in the ballads and folklore of Bengal - Why is it so? Cite reasons.
7. Who established the Vikramashila University? What were its key features?
8. Write a short note on the flourishing art and literature during the Pala rule.
9. Explain any 3 points about the religious and cultural renaissance during the 700-1000 CE in Bharat.

REARRANGE THE EVENTS IN CHRONOLOGICAL ORDER

1. (a) Western Chaulukyas make Kalyani their capital
   (b) Krishna III expands the Rashtrakuta empire
   (c) Govinda III is succeeded by Amoghavarsha
   (d) Kailasa temple is built
2. (a) Devapala expands the Pala empire to its maximum
   (b) Dharmapala builds the Somapura Mahavihara
   (c) Gopala is elected as the king of the Palas
   (d) Vijaya Sena establishes an independent empire in Bengal

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Your knowledge Partner

PICTURE BASED QUESTIONS
MAP WORK



1. Where can this monument be found?
2. Who built this monument?
3. On which currency issued by the Government of India, can you find this monument?



1. Where can this UNESCO monument be found?
2. What style of architecture does it depict?
3. Who were the deities worshipped by this lineage of rulers?

Mark the following places on the outline map of India

- The place where Kailasa temple was built by Krishna I.
- The place to control where the Tripartite struggle happened.
- The city built by Amoghavarsha.